

not need any of those. (Read *Graphic Equalisers And Music Volume* to learn why.) Both the Zen Micros and the Sony NW-HD5 have eight preset equalisers, while the rest have five.

It can be annoying to turn on your PC every time you want to charge your MP3 player. A separate power adapter is a wise accessory. Only the Creative Zen Micro, apart from the Sony NW-HD5 and NW-A1000, provide a separate power adapter.

Ergonomics And Ease Of Use

Among the products we received, we preferred Apple's interface, which is simple and responds precisely to the touch. After the iPod are the Creative Zen Micro and Zen MicroPhoto. Both have nearly the same menu structure: the Zen MicroPhoto has the advantage of a colour screen. Sony's NW-A1000 also has a good interface with a well laid-out menu structure; compared to this, the Sony NW-HD5's interface seemed a bit arid. However, the notable feature of its interface is the "Orient Screen" feature, by which you can choose between the landscape and portrait modes. The Creative Zen Neon's interface is no different from those seen in the Flash-based Creative MuVo series.

Synchronisation Tools

Except for the Creative Zen Neon, all the players in this category require installation of a driver and a synchronisation tool in order to transfer data to and from a PC. The iPod needs to be managed using iTunes, while each of the Zen Micros require separate software.

Sony's SonicStage helps transfer files to its NW-HD5, while the NW-A1000 requires the Connect software. The most convenient of all these tools is iTunes. On connecting the iPod to a USB port, it shows up under iTunes as a device. Drag and drop your music and you're done—file transfer begins immediately. You can list video files in the iTunes video playlist, and just right-click to convert the file for playing on the iPod. However, the conversion takes quite a long time as compared to the other



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